Abul Ma'ali was back from Mecca. Akbar sent a few commanders after the sayyid, and rode to Delhi himself. Abul Fazl suggests that Akbar's idea was to probe the 'condition of the people without . . . intermediary' – to investigate, perhaps, how far discontent had spread through the ranks of his nobility. Badauni agrees, writing that Akbar set off for Delhi 'immediately' upon hearing of Abul Ma'ali's onslaughts, 'with the intention of quelling the disturbance'.

It is the same Badauni, however, who proposes a sudden twist in Akbar's intentions; for now, he writes, the padishah decided to get himself some Delhi brides. Perhaps he meant to gain, thereby, the loyalty of Delhi's nobility, but the plan backfired: 'a great terror fell upon the city'. It is easy enough to understand why: Akbar's first Delhi bride was 'wonderfully beautiful', but also, already, another man's wife. Once the padishah desired her, however, her husband was bound to relinquish his claims. The 'virtuous lady entered the Imperial Harem' and her husband left to nurse his wounds in the Deccan.

According to Abul Fazl, Akbar arrived in Delhi on 10 January 1564; and if Badauni's story is more than backdoor gossip, then Akbar's courtship must have been as swift and certain as his future military campaigns. Only two days after his arrival, Akbar had already claimed his bride and was now seeing the sights. He had visited the dargah of Nizamuddin and was on his way back, riding past the Khair'ul Manazil madrasa built by Maham Anaka, when an arrow struck him.

According to Badauni and Nizamuddin, the arrow only grazed Akbar's shoulder, but Abul Fazl insists it struck deep, piercing the padishah's flesh 'about the length of a span'. Ten days later, it was still difficult for Akbar to ride, so that he returned to Agra in a '*sukasan*', a litter or, more poetically, a 'boat of dry land'.[12] At any rate, the man who shot him was quickly caught. Qutlug Fulad, the 'presumptuous iron-hearted one',[13] had been standing by the madrasa. According to Ferishta, he was pretending to shoot birds, when suddenly he lowered the angle of his aim and sprung his arrow at Akbar instead. Badauni says the sniper may have been delivering a message from Delhi's discontented nobility, for Akbar now gave up any thoughts of further nuptials in the city. Abul Fazl, however, declares without doubt that Qutlug Fulad, a former slave of Sharafuddin's, had been delegated to Abul